

Diagrammatic Design and the Doctrine of the Trinity in Joachim of Fiore

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In the œuvre of the Calabrian abbot and theologian Joachim of Fiore (c. 1135-1202), there is a profound interplay between the doctrine of the Trinity and the medium of diagrams. The reason why an inquiry into this is opportune is that, in today's society, one that is ever more visual in its forms of communication and expression, a re-evaluation of the role of diagrams in theology may be worthwhile. If such a project could have value, there would be few places better to start than with the diagrams of Joachim of Fiore, perhaps the greatest exponent of a diagrammatic theology that the Christian tradition has ever seen. And within Joachim's diagrammatic œuvre, the most widely present doctrine is that of the Trinity. In this paper, however, I will not limit the discussion to an evaluation of how diagrams can help explain a complex doctrine such as the Trinity. Rather, I will try to show how, in a sophisticated thinker like Joachim, the idea of the Trinity becomes as much a "medium" through which to think about and understand diagrams as diagrams become a medium through which to understand the Trinity. I think the implications of Joachim's work for a possible modern "diagrammatic theology" are far-reaching and significant, although within the confines of this paper I cannot go into any detail on this point.

Joachim of Fiore was born around 1135 in Celico, Calabria, which at that time belonged to the Norman Kingdom of Sicily. Trained at the court of justice in Cosenza, as a young man Joachim was destined for the career of an official, but a conversion experience in the Holy Land lead him first to become a lay preacher, then an ordained deacon and finally a Benedictine monk. After being elected abbot of his monastery in Corazzo, Joachim spent one year and a half in the Cistercian monastery of Casamari, where, in order to be able to devote his time to writing, he petitioned Pope Lucius III to allow him to be relieved of his duties, to which the Pope readily agreed. A couple of years later, Joachim retired to a hermitage in Petralata and finally founded a new religious order, the core of which was a monastery at Fiore in Calabria. During his lifetime, Joachim received approbation from no fewer than three Popes, and although his reputation was damaged by the condemnation of one aspect of his doctrine of the Trinity by the Fourth Lateran Council, he continued to be held in high esteem for his holy life by many, including figures of the stature of Dante.

Amongst his teachings, the most famous by far is his idea of the three stages of history, each one associated with a member of the Trinity. Indeed, the doctrine of the Trinity is more than a topic among others in Joachim's work, many passages of which are organised according to an underlying visual concept of the Trinity like an implicit diagram. At the same time, Joachim also designed real diagrams, almost none of which are without Trinitarian implications, and quite a few of which represent the Trinity as a framework carrying further theological contents. It makes a lot of sense to claim that a number of Joachim's diagrams function as a "Trinitarian medium", and also that his respective approach to the Trinity renders it a "diagrammatic doctrine".

In what follows, I will enquire into the interplay between the doctrine of the Trinity and diagrammatic design in Joachim of Fiore. After some further introductory considerations, I will present the genre of diagrams in general and their role in Joachim's œuvre in particular. Then, I shall discuss the way the Trinity proves to be a "diagrammatic doctrine" and also a medium in Joachim. Finally, I will interpret Joachim's two major diagrams, the "Ten-Chord Psalter" and the "Trinitarian Circles" (which form part of his collection of figures called the *Liber Figurarum*), and I will show how they constitute what may be termed a "Trinitarian medium". At the end I will offer some concluding remarks on the significance of Joachim's use of diagrams for a possible modern "diagrammatic theology".

At the level of explicit statements, Joachim himself is mostly, but not entirely, unaware of the reciprocal relationship between his medium-like use of the Trinity and his Trinitarian view of diagrams as a medium. What, for instance, the whole first book of one of his main works, the *Psalterium decem chordarum* strives to analyse, is at first glance only one aspect of this reciprocity, that is, only the diagrammatic representation of the Trinity. Indeed, what the lengthy expositions of this book first appear to enquire into is the way in which the triangular shape of an instrument, the ten-chord psalter, represents the triune God. There is no doubt that the geometrical shape of a triangle is a medium more or less appropriate for rendering the idea of three persons in one substance. At a certain point, Joachim calls the psalter a "similitude" of the Trinity¹; on another occasion, he describes their relation as a kind of a "containing": the figure of the ten-chord psalter contains the "sacred mystery" of the Trinity². The concepts of similitude and container suggest access through an inferior medium to a superior content, as if the role of the psalter were confined to that of mediating the Trinity. At another point of his work, however, Joachim's instructions

1. JOACHIM OF FIORE, *Psalterium decem chordarum*, ed. K.-V. SELGE, Rome, Istituto Storico Italiano per il Medio Evo, 2009, p. 31 (hereafter I will refer to this edition through this abbreviation: *Psalt.*).

2. *Psalt.*, p. 108.

as to how to draw the triangular psalter figure with regard to the Trinity (starting with the phrases *incipie scribere* and *incipis scribere*) make clear that the figure's role is rather a kind of demonstration of the Trinitarian dogma³. In other words, the psalter is designed on the basis of preliminary knowledge about the Trinity, so that one approaches the former by means of the latter. The possibility of such a Trinitarian view of the diagrammatic figure presupposes a preliminary diagrammatic view of the doctrine of the Trinity: in this regard, it is the doctrine that serves as a medium mediating the figure.

What I have tried to explain so far as a kind of reciprocity between the Trinity and the diagrammatic medium in Joachim of Fiore is present in nutshell in the often-cited passage in which he constructs a narrative about how his Trinitarian psalter figure was given to him in a moment of vision. Joachim gives an account of this vision of the ten-chord psalter in the context of a great inner struggle he experienced about the nature of the Trinity upon entering the abbey church of Casamari:

In the meantime, when I had entered the church to pray to Almighty God before the holy altar, there came upon me an uncertainty concerning belief in the Trinity as though it were hard to understand or to hold that three Persons were one God and one God three Persons. When that happened I prayed with all my might. I was very frightened and I was moved to call on the Holy Spirit whose feast day it was to deign to show me the holy mystery of the Trinity. The Lord has promised us that the whole understanding of truth is to be found in the Trinity. I repeated this and began to pray the psalms to complete the number I had intended. At this moment without delay the shape of a ten-stringed psalter appeared in my mind. The mystery of the holy Trinity shone so brightly and clearly in it that I was at once impelled to cry out: "What God is as great as our God?"⁴.

Although it is true that the psalter figure may function here as a medium through which one can contemplate the mystery of the Trinity, it is also essential to recognise that, in spite of all his uncertainty and despair, Joachim had preliminary knowledge about the Trinity prior to receiving the image of the psalter. He is very much aware of the doctrine

3. *Ibid.*, pp. 70-71.

4. "Interea cum ingrederer oratorium et adorarem omnipotentem Deum coram sancto altari, accidit in me velut hesitatio quedam de fide Trinitatis, acsi difficile esset intellectu vel fide esse tres personas unum Deum et unum Deum tres personas. Quod cum accideret timui valde et conterritus vehementer compulsus sum invocare Spiritum sanctum cuius sacra sollempnitas presens erat, ut ipse michi dignaretur ostendere sacrum misterium Trinitatis, in quo nobis promissa est a Domino omnis notitia *veritatis*. Hec dicens cepi psallere ut ad propositum numerum pervenirem. Nec mora occurrit animo meo forma psalterii decacordi et in ipsa tam lucidum et apertum sacre misterium Trinitatis, ut protinus compellerer exclamare: *Quis Deus magnus sicut Deus noster?*" *Ibid.*, pp. 9-10. The English translation is based on B. MCGINN, *The Calabrian Abbot: Joachim of Fiore in the History of Western Thought*, New York, Macmillan, 1985, p. 22.

that “three Persons are one God and one God three Persons”; what he needs is a concrete image to be able to see and contemplate this doctrine with his mind’s eye. Joachim’s vision of the ten-chord psalter is preconditioned by the doctrine of the Trinity which, in this sense, serves as a medium through which he is ready to experience this vision. The Trinity’s role of a medium also comes to the fore to an even greater degree in one of Joachim’s statements from the above quote that “the Lord has promised us that the whole understanding of truth is to be found in the Trinity”, which is a paraphrase of a crucial verse from the Gospel of John. According to John, Christ promises in his farewell speech to the disciples that “the Spirit of truth [...] will guide you into all the truth” (John 16,13). In like manner, Joachim views (the doctrine of) the Trinity as a guiding principle or a medium (or a fundamental diagram), in which and through which the whole truth will be given to us.

THE TEXTUAL-VISUAL GENRE OF DIAGRAMS AND ITS RELEVANCE TO JOACHIM OF FIORE

As to the forms and the application of diagrams in the Middle Ages, we can see a variety which seems to be almost as wide and rich as in our contemporary culture⁵. Diagrams were applied in many fields, such as astronomy, logic, history, exegesis and law. They also assumed several kinds of visual forms, such as geometric shapes like circles, triangles or squares, shapes of artefacts like wheels, ladders or various kinds of buildings, vegetative forms like trees, and also anthropomorphic and animal figures. The role of these shapes and forms could be symbolic (if they contributed to the message of the diagram), mnemonic (if they helped the viewer commit the diagram to memory) or purely decorative. As regards the general purpose of diagrams in the Middle Ages, this also varies: they could serve didactic, mnemonic or contemplative functions, for instance (this latter kind of function is mostly relevant to diagrams of a theological-exegetical nature).

While diagrams unquestionably carry some features specific to the historical period in which they were produced, their possible definitions may also transcend the limits of a particular time. Diagrams may be viewed as “pictorial, yet abstract, representations of information”⁶. They may also be considered as “abstract graphic portrayals of the subject

5. A detailed exploration of the forms and application of medieval diagrams can be found in M. EVANS’s groundbreaking article: *The Geometry of the Mind*, in *Architectural Association Quarterly* 12/4 (1980) 32-55.

6. Michael Anderson’s definition is from a text he published on the Internet: <http://zeus.cs.hartford.edu/~anderson/intro.html>.

matter they represent”⁷, or as “simplified figures [...] intended to convey essential meaning”⁸.

Common to the above three definitions is that, first, they identify diagrams as representations of “mental” kinds of entities (like “information”, “subject matter”, “meaning”); second, they see diagrams as abstractions and simplifications of these entities; third, they attribute to diagrams a visual quality (making use of terms like “pictorial representations”, “graphic portrayals”, “figures”).

First, diagrams may be viewed as representations of a “mental” world. This insight can also be formulated the following way: what diagrams reflect is not the world of physical objects (as, for example, photographs do), but a world of “information”, “subject” and “meaning” which, we must conclude, is inherent in the operation of language. Diagrams can by no means be treated apart from language, not only because they necessarily include textual elements, but also because they are always accompanied by linguistic expressions which are “outside” them: whether in the Middle Ages or in contemporary culture, diagrams are mostly embedded in the prose they elucidate, and, even if they are not, they are in need of understanding through language.

Second, diagrams are abstractions and simplifications of entities expressible through language. They imply an equivalence between a simpler, more concise or “more abstract” textual-visual reality (that is, the diagram itself) and a lengthier, more complex or more concrete linguistic one. This equivalence can also be formulated in terms of the difference between what the producer and what the recipient of a diagram does. While the producer *enfolds* into a diagram an idea or a group of ideas expressible through a lengthier prosaic discourse, the recipient *unfolds* a diagram the other way around⁹.

Third, diagrams are always endowed with a striking visual quality, through which they are able to perform their task of simplification and abstraction. This visual quality implies a resemblance of diagrams to their subject matter only in a very specific sense: they reflect the relations

7. R.K. LOWE, *Diagrammatic Information: Techniques for Exploring Its Mental Representation and Processing*, in *Information Design Journal* 7/1 (1993) 3-18, at p. 3.

8. B.S. HALL, *The Didactic and the Elegant: Some Thoughts on Scientific and Technological Illustrations in the Middle Ages and Renaissance*, in B. BRAIGIE (ed.), *Picturing Knowledge: Historical and Philosophical Problems Concerning the Use of Art in Science*, Toronto, University of Toronto Press, 1996, 3-39, at p. 9. References and respective definitions according to notes 6, 7 and the present note can also be found via the following link: <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Diagram>.

9. Cf. S. BOGEN – F. THÜRLEMANN, *Jenseits der Opposition von Text und Bild: Überlegungen zu einer Theorie des Diagramms und des Diagrammatischen*, in A. PATSCHOVSKY (ed.), *Die Bildwelt der Diagramme Joachims von Fiore: Zur Medialität religiös-politischer Programme im Mittelalter*, Ostfildern, Jan Thorbecke Verlag, 2003, 1-22, at p. 8.

between the conceptual parts of their subject matter by representing these parts and relations in a visual arrangement¹⁰. In other words, diagrams resemble their subject matter in terms of a visual surface displaying the components and the whole of a conceptual entity. What achieves such mediation between the conceptual and the visual fields is the textual dimension of diagrams. A text may be referred to as “written language”, conceptual in so far as it is “language”, and visual in so far as it is “written”. Textual elements are not only indispensable to diagrams, but they can also turn out to be sufficient for forming them. Since texts have an inherent visual capacity, it is misleading to talk about textual and visual elements of a diagram in a complementary manner. As all diagrammatic elements are necessarily visual, it is more appropriate to divide them up into textual and non-textual ones. Given the necessary visual character of texts, it is also clearly incorrect to render the genre of diagrams as an autonomous third between the two alleged “supermedia” of text and image¹¹. It is no exaggeration to claim that texts have not only a visual, but also a diagrammatic capacity. The conventions of the way we read a prose text (from above to below, and, for instance, in the case of Roman script, from the left to the right) can easily make us forget that the loci of the written words are variable. A basic example of such variability may be a horizontal list of words in a prose text, which can be converted into a separate vertical list, that is, an elementary diagram¹². Another (only slightly more advanced) example of a diagrammatic operation through variable textual loci is the transformation of a horizontal list like “Father, Son, Holy Spirit” into a triangular arrangement, carrying extra meaning in comparison with its previous form.



The above triangular position of the Trinitarian names implies that each of them has direct relations to the other two, whereas their arrangement in the manner of a list, horizontal or vertical, bears no such meaning. Besides, it is also clear that a possible addition of an actual graphic triangle to the above figure would not put an end to the priority of the textual elements, a priority which arises from their capacity to combine the conceptual and the visual fields.

While diagrams include language and require interpretation using language, it is also true that, as the figures of Joachim of Fiore bear witness, they can turn out to be tools that are indispensable for the elucidation of

10. *Ibid.*, p. 9.

11. *Ibid.*, pp. 2-3.

12. Cf. EVANS, *The Geometry of the Mind* (n. 5), p. 39.

a massive bulk of complicated text¹³. The reason why the discovery and publication of Joachim's collection of diagrammatic figures, the *Liber Figurarum*, marked the beginning of a new phase in Joachim studies is that this collection "acts as a magnifying glass through which his chief concepts are seen with a lucidity often lacking in the involved disquisitions of his writings"¹⁴.

Diagrams were as essential for Joachim in organising his complex thought as they are for his readers to deciphering them. In Joachim's exposition of ideas, diagrams are not subsequent representations of what he has already thought through, but integral parts of his intricate thinking process¹⁵. Joachim had a peculiar kind of imagination that conjured up a rich variety of number patterns from biblical and ecclesiastical history, which were in great need of a real or imaginary diagrammatic organisation before their final elaboration in prose¹⁶. These number patterns take on their simplest diagrammatic form through concordant lists of generations: such lengthy enumerations of biblical names constitute a significant part of one of Joachim's main works, the *Liber de concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*. It is hard to imagine how he could possibly have elaborated his numerical ideas about the history of salvation without actually executing these elementary diagrams on parchment. And what Joachim did by means of the lists of generations he also realised through many kinds of other diagrams which appear in the manuscripts of his major works¹⁷. The psalter figure, for instance, has several versions in unfolding Joachim's doctrine of the Trinity on the pages of his *Psalterium decem chordarum*. After serving as analytical and explanatory tools to his works throughout his writing career¹⁸, Joachim's diagrams found their most spectacular place in the *Liber Figurarum*, which consists of figures elaborated and developed from their earlier versions, and which relates to the whole of his œuvre in the way in which each of his earlier figures does to a distinct textual locus in one of his works.

13. Cf. M. RAININI's remark that the diagrammatic medium makes possible "una comunicazione più immediata della speculazione dell'abate [sc. Joachim], che è invece meno distinguibile nell'organizzazione, a volte contorta e ridefinita, e nella prosa, spesso farraginosa, delle opere maggiori". *Disegni dei tempi: Il "Liber Figurarum" e la teologia figurativa di Gioacchino da Fiore*, Rome, Viella, 2006, p. 18.

14. M. REEVES – B. HIRSCH-REICH, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore*, Oxford, Clarendon, 1972, Preface, vi-vii.

15. Cf. RAININI, *Disegni* (n. 13), pp. 22 and 25.

16. Cf. REEVES – HIRSCH-REICH, *The Figurae* (n. 14), pp. 20-21.

17. In distinguishing them from their more sophisticated versions in the *Liber Figurarum*, Reeves and Hirsch-Reich called these diagrams adjacent to Joachim's major works "textual figures". See *ibid.*, p. 23.

18. It has paradigmatic significance that the first section of Joachim's earliest work, the so called *Genealogia*, is the description of a genealogical tree diagram which is in fact executed at the end of two of the extant manuscripts of this work. See G.L. POTESTÀ, *Die "Genealogia": Ein frühes Werk Joachims von Fiore und die Anfänge seines Geschichtsbildes*, in *Deutsches Archiv für Erforschung des Mittelalters* 56 (2000) 55-101.

THE TRINITY AS "DIAGRAMMATIC DOCTRINE"

The doctrine standing out as the most famous component in the whole of Joachim's teaching is undoubtedly his approach to the Trinity as manifested in the course of the history of salvation. Indeed, it may be claimed that Joachim's most original idea lies in the connection he made between a historical manifestation of the Trinitarian persons and a sense of progress in history: a connection which implies that an age of higher perfection is still to come under the auspices of the Holy Spirit¹⁹. Although this connection had been well prepared in the monastic literature of the 12th century (and a few authors had in fact been on the verge of Joachimism)²⁰, Joachim was the first author who did not shrink back from teaching that, long after the central event of Incarnation, Christ's Church is still to experience a new and higher spiritual climax.

Original as Joachim's teaching is of the past age of the Father, the present age of the Son and the coming age of the Holy Spirit, we would not do justice to the fullness of his Trinitarian thought if we confined it to these oversimplified terms. In contrast to such a sequential delineation of the historical activity of the three persons, it is essential to note that Joachim laid great emphasis on the unity of the Trinity, which goes hand in hand with his orthodox concept of the ubiquitous cooperation of the three persons in creation and history. It is also important to realise that his historical approach to the Trinity is sophisticated enough to reflect basic propositions of the Trinitarian dogma such as the double procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and the Son: in Joachim's translation into historical terms, this double procession means that the age of the Spirit began as early as Old Testament prophecy (in the age of the Father) and the foundation of monasticism (in the age of the Son). Moreover, Joachim's doctrine of the Trinity cannot be confined to historical ideas. Even if there are manifold equivalences between his approach to the Trinity through historical progress and his understanding of it within the transcendental Godhead, it would be an error to say that he was not aware of this foundational difference, and that the Trinity as Godhead beyond history was of no interest to him²¹. At the same time, however focused Joachim can sometimes be on

19. I can only say "it may be claimed", as I cannot ignore the debate between two Joachim scholars, Marjorie Reeves and Robert E. Lerner, concerning the originality of Joachim's thought. Reeves contended that Joachim's Trinitarian speculation about history and especially his expectation of an imminent age of the Spirit was his most groundbreaking idea (see M. REEVES, *The Originality and Influence of Joachim of Fiore*, in *Traditio* 36 [1980] 269-316), whereas in Lerner's opinion this idea only came about as a consequence of Joachim's revolutionary (and chiliast) reading of the Book of Revelation (see R.E. LERNER, *Joachim of Fiore's Breakthrough to Chiliasm*, in *Cristianesimo nella storia* 6 [1985] 489-512).

20. Cf. REEVES, *The Originality and Influence* (n. 19), pp. 269-287.

21. Cf. MCGINN, *The Calabrian Abbot* (n. 4), p. 169.

the inner relations of the triune God, his view of the Trinity often functions as a lens through which a great multitude of the things of the world and history can be seen more clearly. As Bernard McGinn puts it,

For the abbot of Fiore the Trinity is always primary. It is not that cosmos and history in some way change or condition God, but rather that history *must* adopt the structure it does precisely because God, its creator, is three Persons²².

Therefore, it is not through our cognitive powers that we recognise a Trinitarian structure in history; it is not the case that we draw conclusions about the existence of the triune God on the basis of what we see in history. Joachim contends, rather, that, as the Trinity was revealed by Jesus Christ²³, so we are able to look at history in a Trinitarian way.

In assuming this Trinitarian structure, various entities from both history and the inner life of the Godhead can be represented within a foundational threefold diagram that is formed by the persons of the Trinity. The Trinity functions like a diagram in Joachim, but it is hard to say whether it is his peculiar imagination or the Trinity's own logic that is the source of such diagrammatic operation. After all, the doctrine of the Trinity is a numerical one, in which, as we will see below, the number three easily multiplies into further numbers, whereby the three basic compartments of the Trinity's diagram also multiply into further ones. What these threefold or multiplied compartments offer are diagrammatic places for further contents which can make up both real and imaginary diagrams, that is, those that are actually executed by Joachim, and those lurking behind his texts and organising them.

Such real and imaginary diagrams come to take shape by what Joachim calls the three *propria* or *proprietaes*, the five *relationes*, and the seven *modi* of the Trinity²⁴.

The personal properties of the members of the Trinity emerge as a major topic in the first book of Joachim's *Psalterium decem chordarum*. First Joachim points out that what each person has is the undivided divine substance which is the same integral whole in the case of each, except that "the property (*proprium*) of the Father is to be Father, the property of the Son is to be Son, and the property of the Holy Spirit is to be Holy Spirit"²⁵. With this initial laconic statement, Joachim lays the foundation of an imaginary diagram which, in what follows, he fills with further contents. He proves by means of biblical references that the property of power (*potentia*) is to be attributed to the Father, the property of wisdom (*sapientia*) to the Son,

22. *Ibid.*, p. 161.

23. See *Liber introductorius in Apocalypsim*, Venice, 1527, f. 25rb.

24. For a summary of the Trinitarian *proprietaes*, *relationes* and *modi*, see *Psalt.*, p. 194.

25. *Ibid.*, p. 56.

and the property of will or love (*voluntas vel amor*) to the Holy Spirit²⁶. Later on, it is a long quote from Augustine's *De Trinitate* that helps Joachim show God's various historical activities as properties, each of which belong to one of the Trinitarian persons: for instance, the birth from the Virgin Mary and the crucifixion under Pontius Pilate to the Son, the miracle at Pentecost to the Holy Spirit, the heavenly words about Jesus Christ being a beloved son (Luke 3,22: "You are my Son, whom I love") to the Father²⁷. Then Joachim goes on comparing the three patriarchs Abraham, Isaac and Jacob to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit on the basis of their "fatherhood": just as all the three patriarchs can be called *pater*, so the property of fatherhood can be attributed to all the three Trinitarian persons; just as Abraham is not the son of any patriarch, so God the Father is the principle without origin, from which the other two persons originate²⁸. The patriarchs, the historical activities, the properties of power, wisdom and will or love – all these examples may emerge as contents in a threefold imaginary diagram of the Trinitarian properties that is constituted by the basic figure of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

There is a further intriguing passage, in which the persons of the Trinity and their properties form an imaginary diagram with the so-called three main *instrumenta* of monastic life:

The first of them [that is, of the three main "instruments" or means of monastic life] is manual work, the second is study [*studium lectionis*], the third is devotion to prayer and psalmody. The fear of the Lord operates in the obedience of manual activity, wisdom operates in study, and love in prayer and confession. We are supposed to obey because of the fear that is the Father, to study because of the wisdom that is the Son, to pray and sing psalms because of the love that is the Holy Spirit. It is necessary to fear in manual work, to be wise in study, to love in psalmody. We unite with the Father through obedient work [*per opus obedientie*], we join the Son through study, and cling to the Holy Spirit through devoted psalmody [...] ²⁹.

This passage seems to have an underlying diagrammatic figure which organises the prose text in a table-like manner.

Joachim's teaching of the five *relationes* follows diagrammatic patterns, just as his doctrine of the *proprietaes* does. Indeed, in discussing these Trinitarian relations, he executes real diagrams as well. He recapitulates in a table (see below) what he terms as 1) the Father's relation to the Son, 2) the Son's relation to the Father, 3) the Father's and the Son's relation to the Holy Spirit, 4) the Son's and the Holy Spirit's relation to

26. *Ibid.*, pp. 59-60. Cf. pp. 97-98.

27. *Ibid.*, pp. 93-94.

28. *Ibid.*, p. 95.

29. *Ibid.*, p. 102.

the Father, and 5) the Father's, the Son's and the Holy Spirit's relation to the whole creation³⁰:

First relation	of the Father	to the Son	because only the Father begets the Son
Second relation	of the Son	to the Father	because only the Son is begotten by the Father
Third relation	of the Father and the Son	to the Holy Spirit	because two send one
Fourth relation	of the Son and the Holy Spirit	to the Father	because two are sent by one
Fifth relation	of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit	to creation	because the three are one creator who is the maker of the whole creation

After delineating the above structure of the Trinitarian relations, Joachim moves on to another one, in which he ignores the mutual relations between the Father and the Son, and extends those relations in which all the three persons participate. To demonstrate his modified set of the five relations and to recast his initial diagram, he makes use of five generations of Old Testament patriarchs as shifting allegories of the Trinitarian persons³¹. Abraham designates the Father alone, as it is only the Father who sends the Son and the Holy Spirit. Isaac designates both the Father and the Son, since it is both the Father and the Son who send the Holy Spirit. Jacob designates all the three persons, because they are one God who is the creator of all. Joseph designates both the Son and the Holy Spirit, since both of them are sent by the Father. Finally, Ephraim designates the Holy Spirit alone, as it is only the Spirit who is sent by the Father and the Son. This set of relations forms the following diagram of Joachim³²:

Abraham (Father)	Isaac (Father)	Jacob (Father)		
	Isaac (Son)	Jacob (Son)	Joseph (Son)	
		Jacob (Holy Spirit)	Joseph (Holy Spirit)	Ephraim (Holy Spirit)

30. *Ibid.*, pp. 201-203. The table above is a schematic transcription of Joachim's figure as executed in the following manuscript: Padua, Biblioteca Antoniana MS lat. 322, fol. 25r. (cf. *Psalt.*, Table 4 and Figure 8 on p. 202).

31. *Ibid.*, pp. 203-207.
 32. Again, this table is a schematic transcription. It is based on the diagram as featured by the Padua manuscript (as in note 30) on fol. 25v. (Cf. *Psalt.*, Table 6 and Figure 9 on p. 205). Originally, the figure contains only the names of the patriarchs. To make it clearer, I have extended it by adding the names of the Trinitarian persons.

Moreover, this diagram serves as a foundation for Joachim's subsequent presentation of five historical stages which belong to the Trinitarian persons, as presented in each of the five columns of the diagram³³. The first stage is the age of the patriarchs before the law (*ante legem*), in which God was only known as Father. The second stage is a period under the law (*sub lege*) including Israel's wandering in the desert, the conquest of the Holy Land and the age of the Judges. According to Joachim, this stage belongs to both the Father and the Son, the latter of which was present in the events of this stage in a hidden way, that is, in the shape of the Lord's angel who often appears in the biblical narrative. Joachim calls the third stage the age under the kings and the prophets (*sub regibus et prophetis*), in which the mystery of the whole Trinity appeared, since, at this stage, Scripture more frequently speaks about the Spirit as well, as he dwelt in the kings and the prophets. The fourth stage coincides with the time of the New Testament up to Joachim's present. This stage is the period, in which, as being sent from the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit operate in a more manifest way than in the previous stages. What would start from Joachim's own time is the fifth stage, in which the Holy Spirit would operate at a higher level than he did at the previous stages, spreading his "Gospel", which is nothing other than a deeper understanding of Christ's.

What Joachim's teaching of the five *relationes* implies as a "diagrammatic multiplication" inside the Trinity takes on another form in his exposition of the seven Trinitarian *modi*³⁴. These seven "modes" represent all possible variations within the group of the three persons as a kind of mathematical set. In considering these variations, Joachim recognises that he can take 1) a single person in itself, 2) a combination of two persons, and 3) all the three persons. He also realises that all variations can be predicated as "one God". Accordingly, the Father is one God; the Son is one God; the Holy Spirit is one God; the Father and the Son are one God; the Father and the Holy Spirit are one God; the Son and the Holy Spirit are one God; the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit are one God. To demonstrate his point with a historical example from the created world, Joachim subjects a set of three patriarchs, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, to the same operation, predicating all variations of them as "one flesh" (*una caro*). As a matter of fact, Joachim's description of the seven *modi* has an underlying diagram, which he reveals and executes in a figure made up of seven circles³⁵.

Although the three *proprietaes*, the five *relationes* and the seven *modi* form but one segment of Joachim's intricate doctrine of the Trinity, their

33. See *Psalt.*, pp. 208-214.

34. See *ibid.*, pp. 217-219.

35. See Figure 1 at the end of the article (p. 640). Like the above two figures in the text, this one is also a schematic transcription. Joachim's diagram appears in the Padua manuscript (as in note 30) on fol. 27v. (Cf. *Psalt.*, Table 7a and Figure 12 on p. 218).

numerical nature and related diagrammatic character clearly show how much this doctrine is susceptible to diagrammatic operation.

Whatever importance they have in Joachim's diagrammatic understanding of the Trinity, there is a basic diagram in it which is even more important and fundamental than the *proprietates*, *relationes* and *modi*. This basic diagram is actually a double one, and Joachim calls it the two *diffinitiones*. Although this double diagram may be regarded as "imaginary", as it exerts an underlying diagrammatic force in many passages of Joachim's œuvre, he also illustrates it in an exemplary way through the symbolic pair of the upper case letter A and the lower case letter ω. As the "Alpha" and the "Omega" constitute a symbol representing Jesus Christ and God the Father in the Book of Revelation³⁶, Joachim makes use of them to illustrate the way the Father sends both the Son and the Holy Spirit (this is the *prima diffinitio* that Joachim also calls *missio*), and the Holy Spirit proceeds from both the Father and the Son (*secunda diffinitio* or *processio*). The Father sends the Son and the Holy Spirit, as the top of the letter A (Father) issues forth in its left-hand stroke (Son) and its right-hand stroke (Holy Spirit); the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son, as the middle stroke (Holy Spirit) of the letter ω emerges from its left-hand stroke (Father) and its right-hand stroke (Son)³⁷.

The Trinitarian *missio* and *processio*, as represented by the letters A and ω, provide a basis for further diagrammatic operations in Joachim's main works, especially his *Liber de Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*. What takes up Book Two, Three and Four of this work almost entirely is Joachim's attempt at an implementation of the two *diffinitiones* into genealogical lists inspired by respective genealogical tables in Scripture. By assigning a definite number of generations to each Trinitarian person, Joachim seeks to show the Trinitarian logic of the *missio* and the *processio* in the totality of history in a detailed diagrammatic way, as the lists of generations assigned cover the whole of history from Adam to the end of the world. The Son's and the Spirit's *missio* from the Father and the Spirit's *processio* from the Father and the Son come to be expressed in terms of a numerical concordance between the respective genealogical columns. The fact that Joachim set about his task several times through various versions of genealogical lists well indicates how powerful a diagrammatic drive the two Trinitarian *diffinitiones* had in his imagination. However, the extant manuscripts of the *Liber de concordia* clearly show that, however reasonable Joachim's

36. Cf. Rev 1,8; 21,6; 22,13.

37. See *Psalt.*, pp. 197 and 199-200. In his *Psalterium decem chordarum*, Joachim describes his A and ω figures together with the upper case O, which represents the unity of the Trinity. However, it is in his *Liber de concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti* that he terms the Trinitarian content of the A and the ω as *diffinitiones*. Cf. *Liber de concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, ed. E.R. DANIEL, Philadelphia, PA, The American Philosophical Society, 1983, p. 80.

enterprise was, he did not manage to display the full dynamism of both *diffinitiones* in a single image of combined genealogical lists³⁸.

Joachim also tried to delineate the mystery of the *missio* and the *processio* in a genealogical tree diagram, as he in fact dedicates many pages of Book Two of his *Liber de concordia* to a description of three tree figures³⁹ which, in contrast to mere genealogical lists, certainly have the extra value of enriching Joachim's Trinitarian view of history with the arboreal imagery of progress. Although at one point in Joachim's text there is a clear hint to a possible execution of this threefold diagram⁴⁰, none of the extant manuscripts bear witness to such a figure. Upon due consideration, this failure is hardly surprising. To do justice to the two *diffinitiones*, Joachim should have had to design a figure which is impossible in terms of the imagery of a tree, as the second tree (that of the Son) should stem from the first (the tree of the Father), while the third (the tree of the Holy Spirit) should grow out of both the first and the second. Joachim himself admits in a passing remark that what he can see with his intellect he can barely render through his tree figures⁴¹. What he saw with his intellect was an imaginary diagram of the Trinitarian *diffinitiones*, which he managed to draw by means of the double figure of the A and the ω , while, at the same time, repeated searching for it in the genealogical lists and trees of biblical history did not lead him to success.

JOACHIM'S DIAGRAMS AS "TRINITARIAN MEDIUM"

While Joachim unfolds his doctrine of the Trinity in diagrammatic terms, it is also true that his diagrams almost never fail to have a Trinitarian dimension⁴². What is more, his œuvre includes major diagrams whose full content and organisation are based on their representation of the Trinity. I shall now present two of them that are the most prominent examples of Joachim's design of a "Trinitarian medium": his Ten-Chord Psalter

38. Several photocopies of relevant manuscript pages and an excellent scholarly evaluation of them can be found in Gian Luca Potestà's contribution to the volume on Joachim's "diagrammatic world" edited by Alexander Patschovsky: G.L. POTESTÀ, *Geschichte als Ordnung in der Diagrammatik Joachims von Fiore*, in PATSCHOVSKY (ed.), *Die Bildwelt der Diagramme Joachims von Fiore* (n. 9), 115-145.

39. See *Liber de concordia* (n. 37), pp. 107-112 and 145-184. Cf. REEVES – HIRSCHREICH, *The Figurae* (n. 14), pp. 31-38; POTESTÀ, *Geschichte als Ordnung* (n. 38), pp. 139-141; ID., *Il tempo dell'Apocalisse: Vita di Gioacchino da Fiore*, Rome, Laterza, 2004, pp. 143-146.

40. See *Liber de concordia* (n. 37), p. 109.

41. See *ibid.*, pp. 169-170.

42. B. MCGINN rightly observed that "almost all Joachim's *figurae* have Trinitarian implications". See his *Theologians as Trinitarian Iconographers*, in J.F. HAMBURGER – A.-M. BOUCHÉ (eds.), *The Mind's Eye: Art and Theological Argument in the Medieval West*, Princeton, NJ, Princeton University Press, 2005, 186-207, at p. 193.

and his Trinitarian Circles. Both of these diagrams form part of Joachim's *Liber Figurarum*, of which they may be the most sophisticated pieces.

The basic scheme of the Ten-Chord Psalter diagram is the figure of a triangle with a blunted top and a large circle in the middle⁴³. The triangle represents the psalter itself which, as we recall, appeared to Joachim in his vision at Casamari as a symbol of the Trinity; the circle in the middle, which renders the sound hole of the instrument, represents the unity of the Trinitarian God. The triangle of the psalter functions as a symbol of the Trinity both by its three angles and its three sides, to which the adjacent captions and inscriptions bear witness. There are captions in the sound hole, too, and also on the ten strings of the instrument, which are indeed visualised by this double sequence of ten captions parallel to the left and right side of the triangle. As we shall see, the strings are as consistent with the Trinitarian logic of the whole figure as the angles, the sides and the sound hole.

There is a profound interplay between the angles and the sound hole in their demonstration of the Trinitarian dogma. Starting from the upper angle, the captions in the angles read counter-clockwise as follows: *Sanctus Pater*, *Sanctus Filius*, *Sanctus Spiritus Sanctus*. The triple adjective *sanc-tus* before the three Trinitarian names forms a unity with the caption *Dominus Deus omnipotens* in the middle of the sound hole, as they are divided parts of a textual unit from Revelation 4,8: "Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God Almighty". While the triple adjective in the angles relates to the triple exclamation and represents the Trinity, the confession of "the Lord God Almighty" in the middle represents the unity of the Godhead⁴⁴. What occupies the very centre of the sound hole and of the whole figure is the cipher IEUE, which corresponds to its three overlapping fragments under each Trinitarian name in the angles: IE (*Pater*), EU (*Filius*), and UE (*Spiritus Sanctus*). This four-letter cipher is the Latin transcription of God's four-letter Hebrew name, the so-called Tetragrammaton. According to Joachim, when split into three overlapping parts, it bears the mystery of the Trinity, while, in itself as an undivided whole, it is the symbol of

43. See Figure 2 (p. 641) that is a reproduction of the psalter figure from the Oxford manuscript of the *Liber Figurarum* (Corpus Christi College, MS 255A fol. 16r), which, in contrast to the Reggio Emilia and the Dresden manuscripts, is most likely to have preserved the original version of this figure. Cf. A. PATSCHOVSKY, *Die Trinitätsdiagramme Joachims von Fiore: Ihre Herkunft und semantische Struktur im Rahmen der Trinitätsikonographie von deren Anfängen bis ca. 1200*, in *Die Bildwelt der Diagramme Joachims von Fiore* (n. 9), 55-114, at pp. 97-99. Note that there is a valuable scholarly work which focuses exclusively on Joachim's Ten-Chord Psalter: Jean Devriendt defended his dissertation on this topic at Strassbourg University in 2001 (J. DEVRIENDT, *Le Psaltérion à dix cordes de l'Abbé Joachim de Flore: Transcription, traduction, annotations et commentaire*).

44. Cf. *Psalt.*, p. 44. After making the above connection between the Trinity and the unity of God as based on Rev 4,8, this locus in the *Psalterium decem chordarum* gives a similar interpretation of Is 6,3 ("Holy, holy, holy is the Lord of Hosts").

God's unity⁴⁵. A further caption in the middle of the sound hole makes a dogmatic claim (*Sancta Trinitas unus Deus*) which concisely expresses the dynamism between three and one involved in the divine name and Revelation 4,8⁴⁶. In the outer circle of the sound hole, there is a quote from the Psalms (Ps 66,8: *Et metuant eum omnes fines terre*), a doxology (*Ipsi gloria*) and a dogmatic statement (*Sed Patris et Filii et Spiritus Sancti una est divinitas*), all of which give praise to one God in three Persons. There is also a dogmatic formula (from the Creed) under the sound hole (*Una sancta ecclesia catholica*), which, in accordance with John 17,21-23, can be read as a statement about the unity and sanctity of the Church corresponding to the unity and sanctity of the Trinitarian God. All these captions and inscriptions adjacent to the sound hole and the angles clearly show how able Joachim's "Trinitarian medium" is to organise quotes, concepts and ideas both from "inside" the doctrine of the Trinity and from "outside" of it.

The principle of organising both Trinitarian and non-Trinitarian contents in a Trinitarian way is also manifest in the inscriptions running parallel to the sides of the triangle. These three blocks of text have the same structure as follows:

- (1) the first and the final verses of each block of fifty psalms from the complete one hundred and fifty, each block related to a Trinitarian Person (that is, Psalms 1–50 come to be related to the Father on the left side, Psalms 51–100 to the Son on the lower side, Psalms 101–150 to the Holy Spirit on the right side);
- (2) an explanatory note for each block of fifty Psalms⁴⁷;
- (3) a statement about an "order" belonging to each age of history and each Person (that is, the order of the *coniugatores*, the married, belongs to the first age and to the Father on the left side, then the order of the clerics belongs to the second age and to the Son on the lower side, and, finally, the order of the monks belongs to the third age and to the Holy Spirit on the right side);

45. In the form of an inscription above the psalter figure, there is further reference to the Tetragrammaton as an "ineffable name that Aaron bore on his forehead": *Hoc est ineffabile nomen Domini quod gerebat in fronte Aaron, scriptum quattuor litteris in hac forma Psalterii altius insignitis, propter quod tetragrammaton nominatur, in quo mirabiliter sancte et individue trinitatis misterium figuratur*. It is important to note that the above-mentioned Trinitarian interpretation and the Latin transcription of the Tetragrammaton is not Joachim's invention, but that of the 11-12th century Jewish author Petrus Alphonsi who converted to Christianity. Cf. PATSCHOVSY, *Die Trinitätsdiagramme* (n. 43), pp. 83-85, 106-114, and POTESTÀ, *Geschichte als Ordnung* (n. 38), pp. 125-126.

46. This dogmatic claim is more elaborated in an inscription running outside the psalter figure on both sides: *Fides catholica est ut unum Deum in Trinitate et Trinitatem in unitate veneremur, neque confundentes personas, neque substantiam separantes*.

47. *Quinquagenarius primus* on the left side, *Quinquagenarius secundus* on the lower side, and *Quinquagenarius tertius* on the right side.

- (4) a fragment from Romans 11,36, which, inserted into a benediction formula, expresses the nature of the given Person (*ex quo omnia* on the side of the Father, *per quem omnia* on the side of the Son, and *in quo omnia* on the side of the Holy Spirit)⁴⁸;
- (5) a further reference to each Person⁴⁹;
- (6) a fragment from the Aaronite Blessing (Numbers 6,24-26) in a way that the entirety of the three fragments from the three sides (6,24; 6,25; 6,26) equals the whole blessing.

In relation to the ten strings, the psalter figure features, in an ascending order, the nine angelic choirs and “man” (as exalted above the choirs) on the left hand side, and the seven gifts of the Holy Spirit and the three theological virtues on the right hand side⁵⁰. The right-side captions must be read according to the left-side ones, as it is by means of the seven gifts of the Spirit and the three theological virtues that humans can reach perfection and ascend above the angels to God. In doing so, they follow Christ who, having assumed human nature in his Incarnation, glorified it above all creation and all the angels in his Ascension, since, as the Letter to the Hebrews puts it, “he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty in heaven”, and so “he became as much superior to the angels as the name he has inherited is superior to theirs” (Heb 1,3-4). The intimate connection between the captions on the left and those on the right is properly formulated in the interpretation of the Ten-Chord Psalter of Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich:

The two sets must rather be connected as wholes, as two sides of an ascent. It is Man himself on his ascent to God who forms the link. The captions on both sides proclaim the same theme, with one difference: on the side of the supernatural Beings Man transcends the angels in ecstatic flight; on the other side, he ascends step by step the ladder of perfection. On the left his exaltation is achieved through Christ; on the right the operation of the Holy Spirit within him predominates. The prominence of *Caritas* in association with Man at the top carries an overtone of the third *status*, for Joachim conceived of the third *status* as embodying in a special way the essence of love. The union of the soul with God through love is the ultimate state of the deified Man⁵¹.

48. The benediction formulas integrating the fragments from Romans 11,36 are as follows: *Benedicat nos Deus ex quo omnia* on the left, (*Benedicat nos*) *Deus noster, per quem omnia* at the bottom, *Benedicat nos Deus in quo omnia* on the right.

49. *Alia est enim persona Patris* on the left, *Alia persona Filii* at the bottom, *Alia est persona Spiritus Sancti* on the right.

50. The captions in an ascending order are as follows: *Angeli, Archangeli, Virtutes, Potestates, Principatus, Dominationes, Throni, Cherubim, Seraphim, Homo* on the left; *Timor Domini, Pietas, Scientia, Fortitudo, Consilium, Intellectus, Sapientia, Fides, Spes, Caritas* on the right.

51. REEVES – HIRSCH-REICH, *The Figurae* (n. 14), p. 206.

It seems, then, that the ten strings with their captions on both sides follow a Trinitarian logic, and they do so in two perspectives that are the mystical ascent of humanity to God and its worldly progress through the three ages or *status* of history. The mystical ascent can be seen in Trinitarian terms, as it is with the help of the Son (according to the captions on the left) and the Holy Spirit (according to those on the right) that humanity ascends to God the Father (in like manner, in the gradually narrowing instrument, the captions themselves also ascend to the upper angle that is the angle of the Father). Moreover, if the tenth and uppermost string with *Homo* and *Caritas* makes a reference to the third and final age, all ten strings can be understood in a historical way as implying a worldly progress through the three ages of the Trinitarian persons. In fact, this is exactly what an inscription above the lower side of the figure does: it assigns the first three strings to the first age, the second three to the second age, the third three to the third age, and the tenth to the “angelic nature” in eternity⁵².

In Joachim’s diagram, there is a multitude of details which the Trinitarian principle holds together in unity. As the three Persons are one, so is the multitude of details. At the level of diagrammatic representation, however, this unity is by no means the unity of substance or essence as required by the orthodox doctrine of the Trinity. There is no doubt that the multitude of details are organised through the doctrine of the Trinity, but the three Persons themselves in the diagram are held together not by a common substance, but the graphic unity of the psalter figure. Although the unity of the Trinity is represented by the sound hole, the latter cannot help being one element among many. Even if Joachim claims that the divine substance is not the sound hole (the sound hole is only an indication of the substance), but the whole psalter⁵³, what we can see through this instrument is hardly a substance, but a multitude of details united in a Trinitarian perspective, while the Trinitarian Persons themselves come to be represented by the complex figure of a triangle. Joachim is at pains to emphasise that it is not the *point*, but the practically unlimited *area* of the angle (which he calls *cornu*, that is, “horn”) between two sides that represents each Person (who, as a consequence, overlap and form a unity with the other two)⁵⁴, yet, in

52. The inscription starts with an allusion to the Ten Commandments as being in accord with the ten strings: *Decem corde decem precepta legis. Alio modo in tribus cordis inferioribus congrue accipimus tres ordines primi status: in tribus aliis tres ordines secundi: in tribus aliis tres ordines tertii: in corda superiori naturam angelicam*. The fact that this inscription is a later addition to the manuscript does not diminish its significance and conformity with the logic of the whole figure. Cf. REEVES – HIRSCH-REICH, *The Figuræ* (n. 14), p. 202, n. 8.

53. See *Psalt.*, p. 43. Cf. B. OBRIST, *La figure géométrique dans l’œuvre de Joachim de Flore*, in *Cahiers de civilisation médiévale X^e-XII^e siècles* 31 (1988) 297-321, at p. 317, and REEVES – HIRSCH-REICH, *The Figuræ* (n. 14), pp. 57 and 200.

54. See *Psalt.*, pp. 53-54. Cf. OBRIST, *La figure géométrique* (n. 53), pp. 314-315.

any case, a triangle remains a complex geometric shape of three distinct sides and three distinct angular points⁵⁵. Just like the sides and the angular points, all the details and the Trinitarian Persons, as carried by the psalter figure, are one in a “collective” sense, that is, in a way in which the Fourth Lateran Council in 1215 interpreted and condemned Joachim’s doctrine of the Trinity. What the Council brought up against Joachim’s teaching was his idea that the Trinity’s unity is the same as the unity of the members in the Church, according to John 17,22 (where Jesus prays to the Father that the faithful “may be one in us as we are one”). By contrast, the Council taught that John 17,22 should be interpreted in an analogical way: while the members of the Church form a collective unity by grace, the Persons of the Trinity form a unity of identity by nature (*identitatis unitas in natura*)⁵⁶. Condemned at Lateran IV as it was, Joachim’s collective understanding of the Trinity’s unity may still offer a key to the contemplation of his diagrammatic design as a “Trinitarian medium”. All contemplation of the Trinity through a medium such as this must start with a collective unity at the visual level. Then this collective unity can be transcended by one of nature or substance, in accordance with the Council’s teaching.

Another fine example of how Joachim’s Trinitarian medium governs all kinds of contents in a Trinitarian way is the diagram of the Trinitarian Circles⁵⁷. This figure could also be called the IΕUE diagram, since it is dominated by the Latin transcription of the Tetragrammaton. The primary teaching of this diagram is that which we already know from the psalter figure: by an adequate combination of its letters, God’s four-letter name can be interpreted in a Trinitarian way. While, however, the divine name is one component among others in the Ten-Chord Psalter, it plays a central role and undergoes more elaboration in the Trinitarian Circles. In the latter, three overlapping circles group the letters of the Tetragrammaton according to the intricate Trinitarian patterns of Twos, Threes and Fours (whereas, as we may recall it, the psalter figure only featured a threefold pattern of the divine name).

To start with the pattern of Threes, there is an inscription above the circles that reads as follows: *Ego sum alpha et ω: Deus Abraam et Deus*

55. Note that Joachim’s figure has a blunted top which renders it a triangle-like trapezium rather than a perfect triangle. The reason for this blunted top is not because Joachim wished to design a trapezium, but because he intended to draw a triangle with one angle dissimilar to the other two. As there is one angle that is markedly different from the other two, so the Father’s role is to be highlighted in comparison with the roles of the Son and the Holy Spirit, since the Father is the absolute origin of the other two Persons, and not the other way around. Cf. *Psalt.*, p. 73.

56. See H. DENZINGER – A. SCHÖNMETZER, *Enchiridion symbolorum definitionum et declarationum de rebus fidei et morum*, Freiburg, Herder, 1997, § 803-806. Cf. MCGINN, *The Calabrian Abbot* (n. 4), pp. 177-178.

57. See Figure 3 at the end of the article (p. 641). This figure is a reproduction of MS Oxford, Corpus Christi College, 255A fol. 7v. The diagram’s name that I use (“Trinitarian Circles”) was given by REEVES – HIRSCH-REICH, *The Figuræ* (n. 14), p. 192.

Ysaac et Deus Jacob ("I am the Alpha and the Omega: the God of Abraham and the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob"). The way this inscription arranges the names of the three patriarchs in relation to the three circles makes clear that the God of Abraham is the Father (whose circle contains the letters IE), the God of Isaac is the Son (whose circle has the letters EU), and the God of Jacob is the Holy Spirit (whose circle bears the letters UE). Accordingly, each circle bears the name of a Trinitarian Person with the related combination of letters in small characters as well (see the uppermost parts of the circles, where it reads: PATER/IE, FILIUS/EU, SPIRITUS SANCTUS/UE)⁵⁸. In like manner, each circle bears a reference to a Person in the middle, too (*persona Patris, persona Filii, persona Spiritus Sancti*). In the lowest parts of the circles, there are further references to ages and, based on 2 Corinthians 12,2, respective "heavens" of history under the auspices of the three Persons (*Primus status / Primum caelum* in the Father's circle, *Secundus status / Secundum caelum* in the Son's circle, and *Tertius status / Tertium caelum* in the Holy Spirit's circle)⁵⁹. Moreover, the figure carries a sequence of captions which also belongs to the pattern of Threes, and runs from outside the Father's circle (on the left) through the middle of each circle to outside the Holy Spirit's circle (on the right). The sequence reads as follows: *Adam; Moyses et Aaron; Iohannes Baptista; presens tempus; finis mundi*. These captions comprise history from the beginning (*Adam*) to the end (*finis mundi*), running through the fulfilments of the three ages: while Moses and Aaron, as mediators of the Law, fulfilled the age of the Father, John the Baptist, announcing Christ, fulfilled the age of the Son, the "present time" will imminently fulfil the age of the Holy Spirit.

The pattern of Twos and the pattern of Fours coincide in the IEUE diagram, as both of these patterns are based on the idea of the double procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and the Son. If we regard the two Persons, from whom the Holy Spirit originates, history follows the pattern of Twos in agreement with two ages, that is, the age of the Father and that of the Son. Accordingly, history can be divided into the age of the Old Testament and that of the New Testament, as two captions in the upper part of the figure indicate (*Vetus Testamentum* and *Novum Testamentum*). However, this twofold pattern will turn out to be a fourfold one if we bear in mind (as Joachim did) that, by his double procession, the Holy Spirit relates both to the Father and to the Son. Translating this insight into

58. Above these captions in the uppermost part of the circles, there is also a three-sentence dogmatic statement which runs across the three circles: *Est Pater in Filio. Est in Verbo Pater. Est in utroque Spiritus ab utroque procedens* ("The Father is in the Son. In the Word is the Father. The Spirit is in both and proceeds from both").

59. In 2 Cor 12,2, Paul speaks about his mystical experience as being "caught up to the third heaven". Joachim interpreted this "third heaven" as an allusion to the third age of history and, as his figure shows, he extended this terminology to the first and second age as well.

historical terms, we can say that, in following the pattern of Twos, history may also follow the pattern of Fours, as the age of the Holy Spirit has its origin in both the age of the Father and that of the Son. Furthermore, if we project this fourfold pattern into the four-letter name IEUE, the double appearance of the letter E may stand for the double procession of the Holy Spirit in history. Accordingly, in the lower part of the diagram, the four fields of the four letters contain four Trinitarian names: *Pater* (I), *Spiritus Sanctus* (E), *Filius* (U), *Spiritus Sanctus* (E). The four names represent two as well as four ages of history, to each of which Joachim assigns the name of a historical protagonist: *Moyses* (protagonist in the age of the Father), *Helyas* (that is, the first coming of the prophet Elijah as protagonist of the age of the Spirit within the age of the Father), *Iohannes Baptista* (protagonist in the age of the Son), *Helyas* (that is, the second coming of the prophet Elijah as protagonist of the age of the Spirit at the end of the age of the Son)⁶⁰. Moreover, the double procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and the Son in fact implies four distinct ages, as a further fourfold sequence of double captions show: the time before the Law with the initiation of the Law (*tempus ante legem / initiatio legis*), the time under the Law with the initiation of the Gospel (*tempus sub lege / initiatio evangelii*), the time under the Gospel with the initiation of the typical understanding of Scripture (*tempus sub evangelio / initiatio tipici intellectus*), the time under the typical understanding of Scripture with the initiation of its anagogical understanding (*tempus sub tipico intellectu / initiatio anagogici intellectus*). The term *tempus tipici intellectus* here stands for the age of a deeper, spiritual understanding of Scripture, while the initiation of its anagogical understanding prefigures heavenly happiness after this fourth age.

What dominates the diagram is the divine name IEUE, which carries further captions and inscriptions that have not been mentioned yet. The four letters appear in the first circle and in the intersection between the three circles in the very middle, too. The intersection (that is the area common to all three circles) also bears the Greek term *tetragrammaton* and the Hebrew word *adonay* that the readers of the Hebrew Bible pronounce when coming across the four-letter name. There are also two further inscriptions that run through the whole figure and reveal something of the biblical background of the Tetragrammaton⁶¹.

60. On the two comings of Elijah in Joachim's thought, see REEVES – HIRSCH-REICH, *The Figurae* (n. 14), pp. 196-198.

61. (1) *Ego Dominus qui apparui Abraam et Ysaac et Jacob in Deo omnipotente et nomen meum non indicavi eis*. ("I am the Lord who appeared to Abraham and Isaac and Jacob as an omnipotent God, and did not reveal my name to them"); (2) *Hoc est ineffabile nomen Dei quod gerebat in fronte Aaron summus pontifex scriptum quattuor litteris in hac pagina insignitis propter quod et a Grecis tetragrammaton nominatur*. ("This is the ineffable name of God that Aaron bore on his forehead and is written in four letters as being shown on this page. Therefore, it is also called Tetragrammaton by the Greeks").

Even if these captions and inscriptions related to the divine name do not contain any explicit reference to the Trinity, the Trinitarian perspective of the entire figure, in which Joachim interprets the name of God and the whole of history, is firm and unquestionable. All the elements of the IEUE figure are carried by a “Trinitarian medium” which presents them according to its own doctrinal rules⁶².

CONCLUSION

The intimate connection in the œuvre of Joachim of Fiore between his diagrammatic output and his understanding of the doctrine of the Trinity is both quite extraordinary and quite ordinary and normal at the same time. It is extraordinary that the most abstract of all Christian doctrines could become the primary source for the extensive diagrammatic output of this exceptional monk; before coming into contact with the work of Joachim, one might have been forgiven for thinking that this would be the very last of all Christian doctrines to be connected with diagrammatic representation. Yet, at the same time, when remembering the definitions of diagrams given above as “representations of mental entities”, “abstractions” and “simplified figures”, we may begin to see the almost natural link between the abstract doctrine of the Trinity and the potential of diagrammatic representation. This is especially so if we can see, as I have tried to show in this paper, that it is too simplistic to understand what Joachim is doing in terms of “explaining the doctrine of the Trinity by means of a diagram”, and that the diagrammatic representations are as much mediated by the doctrine of the Trinity as they are mediating it.

As a very last point, let us return to the opening remark in this paper, that is, the relevance of diagrams for dogmatic and doctrinal theology today. In today’s society, it is no doubt the case that anyone reading a

62. Around the central IEUE diagram, there are five small subordinate figures, all of which are minor expositions of various aspects of Joachim’s doctrine of the Trinity. All these aspects have already been discussed in this article. If we start from the bottom left corner and move clockwise, the figures are the following:

- (1) a lower case Omega figure (ω) representing the double procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and the Son (which, as we recall it, Joachim calls *secunda diffinitio*);
- (2) an Alpha figure (A) showing that the Father sends both the Son and the Holy Spirit (*prima diffinitio*);
- (3) three overlapping circles (with the first one divided into two equal parts) which refer to the four ages of history before the Law, under the Law, under the Gospel and under the typical understanding of Scripture (that is, we have here the same fourfold sequence of ages as in the central IEUE figure where we learn that this scheme is based on the double procession of the Holy Spirit);
- (4) a figure representing the five Trinitarian *relationes* by means of three circles which are interlaced the same way as the circles of the central figure;
- (5) a figure showing the seven Trinitarian *modi* (in the same way as Figure 1 does).

newspaper, a government report or a business plan will be presented with a number of diagrams. We live in a world that is full of diagrammatic representations of data, and it is probably not an exaggeration to say that a person with an average high school education will have at least some ability in understanding diagrams of various kinds. Could this skill be used to the advantage of dogmatic theology? Could the explanation of the doctrine of the Trinity in contemporary society be aided by the use of diagrams that have been suitably devised for the tastes of our day? There is no place to answer a question such as this here. All we can say is that the extensive and illuminating efforts made by Joachim of Fiore to communicate the meaning of the doctrine of the Trinity through diagrams of various kinds raises this question for contemporary theology.

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ABSTRACT. — In the œuvre of Joachim of Fiore (ca. 1135-1202), his Trinitarian way of thinking and his diagrammatic fashion of shaping ideas represent two major and corresponding tendencies. Indeed, the wide interplay between these tendencies allows for a basic conceptual exchange that renders the Trinity as Joachim's "diagrammatic doctrine" and his diagrams as a "Trinitarian medium". On the one hand, Joachim develops the diagrammatic potential that is inherent in the Trinitarian dogma by its numerical character: the three *propria*, the five *relationes*, the seven *modi* and especially the two *diffinitiones* prompt him to approach history and creation through the Trinity as a medium. On the other hand, his drawn diagrams such as the Ten-Chord Psalter and the IEUE Circles are profoundly Trinitarian by making use of the representation of the Trinity as a framework organising further doctrinal contents.

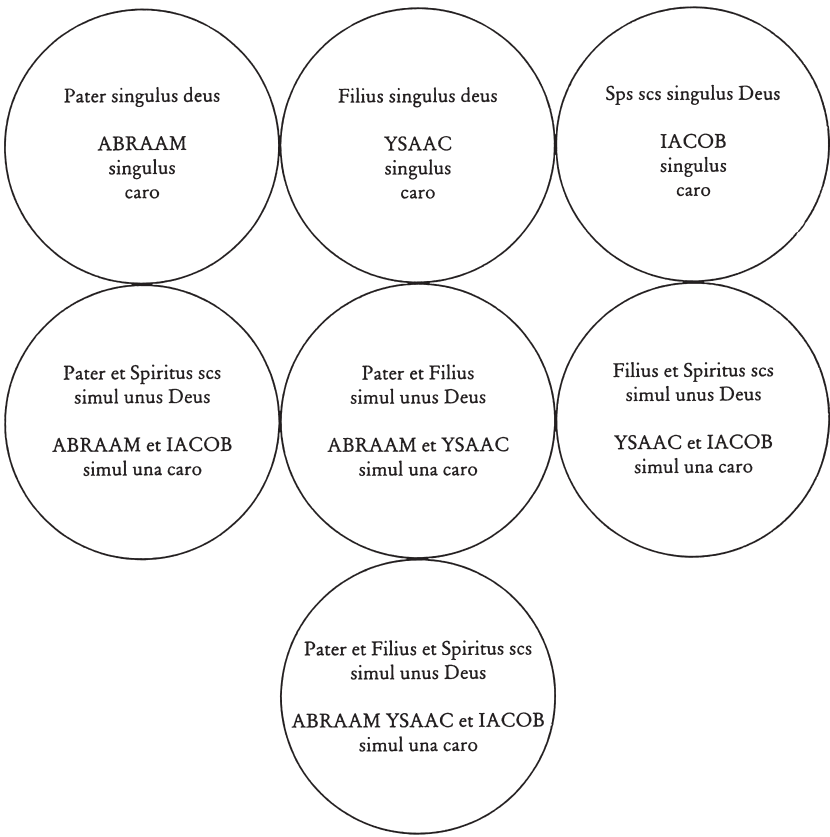


Fig. 1. Padua manuscript,
Biblioteca Antoniana MS lat. 322, fol. 27v.

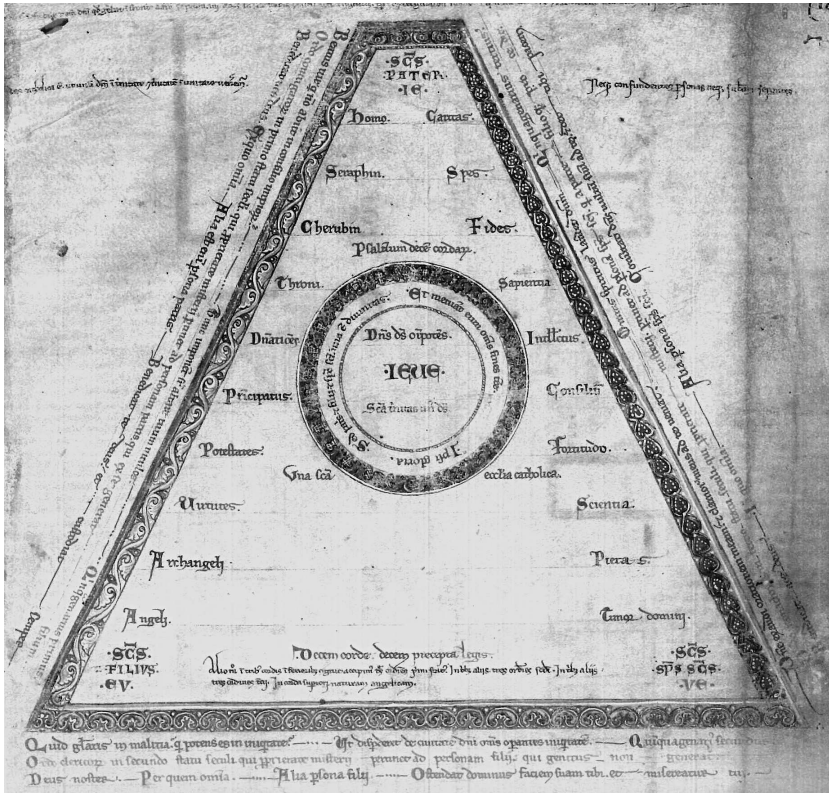


Fig. 2. MS Oxford, Corpus Christi College, 255A fol. 16r.

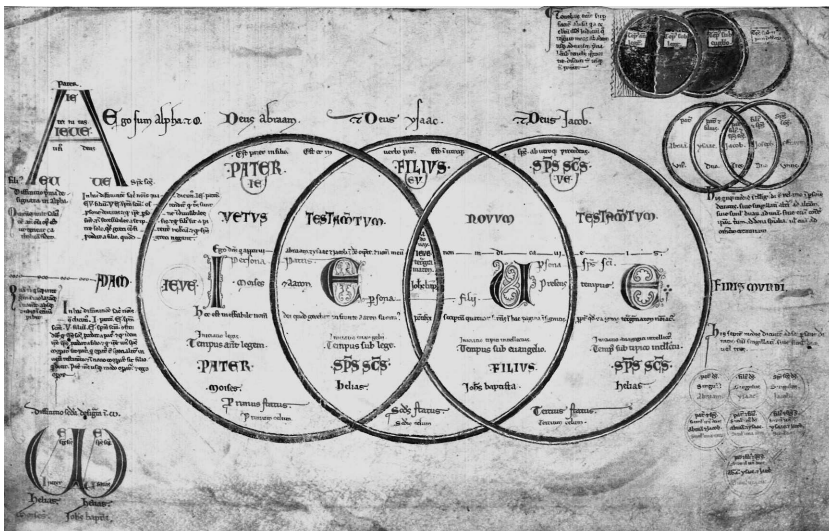


Fig. 3. MS Oxford, Corpus Christi College, 255A fol. 7v.